

The Global Incumbency Advantage

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This paper

- **Do incumbents benefit from an electoral advantage?**

- Extensively studied at the **subnational level** (parliamentary constituencies, mayors...)
- **Little evidence at the national level**
- Holding public office confers many **potential benefits** (name recognition, state resources)
- But there are also **anti-incumbent biases**

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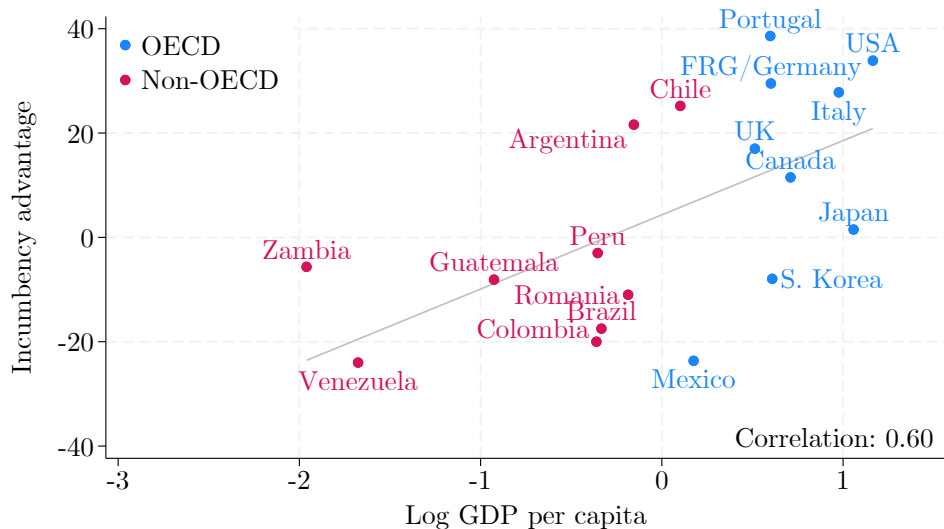
- ① **Meta-analysis** of large literature on the incumbency advantage at the **subnational level**
- ② **First analysis** of the incumbency advantage at the **national level**

Meta-analysis of incumbency effects at the subnational level

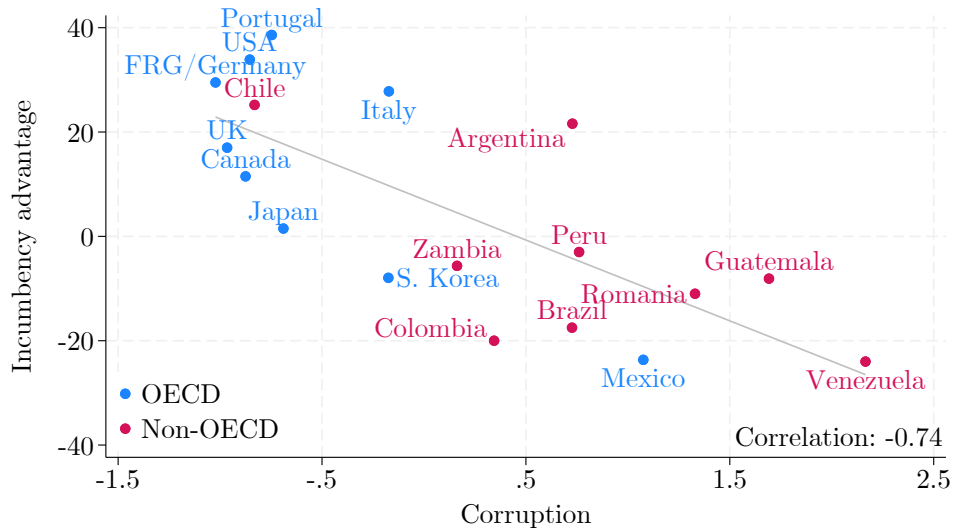
Meta-analysis

- We synthesize **subnational** evidence on incumbency effects
- Focus on **regression discontinuity** estimates
- We recover **96 estimates** from **59 studies**, covering **31 countries**

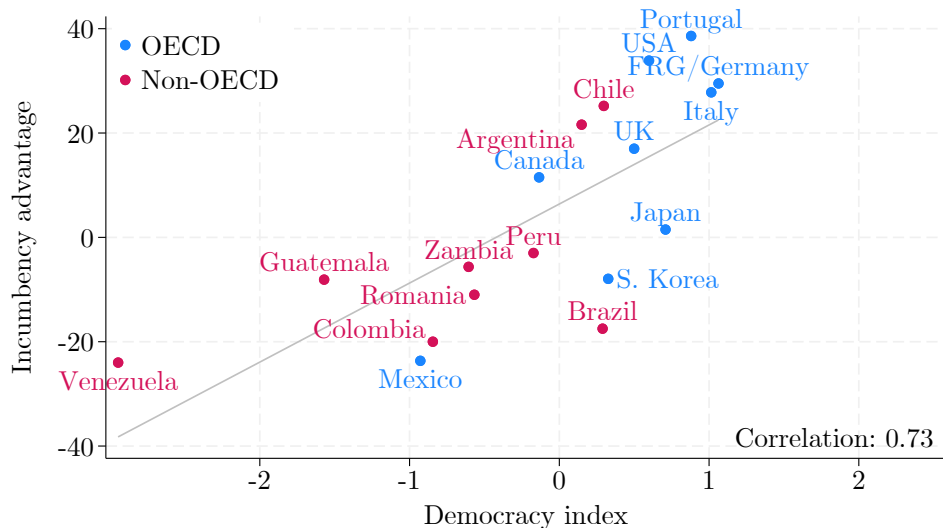
Incumbency advantage positively correlated with GDP per capita



Incumbency advantage negatively correlated with corruption



Incumbency advantage positively correlated with democratic quality



Incumbency effects in national elections

Data

① Elections and electoral results

- All national elections since 1945 (**National Elections Database version 2.0**)
- 3,022 elections: 859 presidential and 2,163 parliamentary

② Leaders and political parties

③ Political regimes and constitutionally defined term lengths

Incumbency advantage in national elections

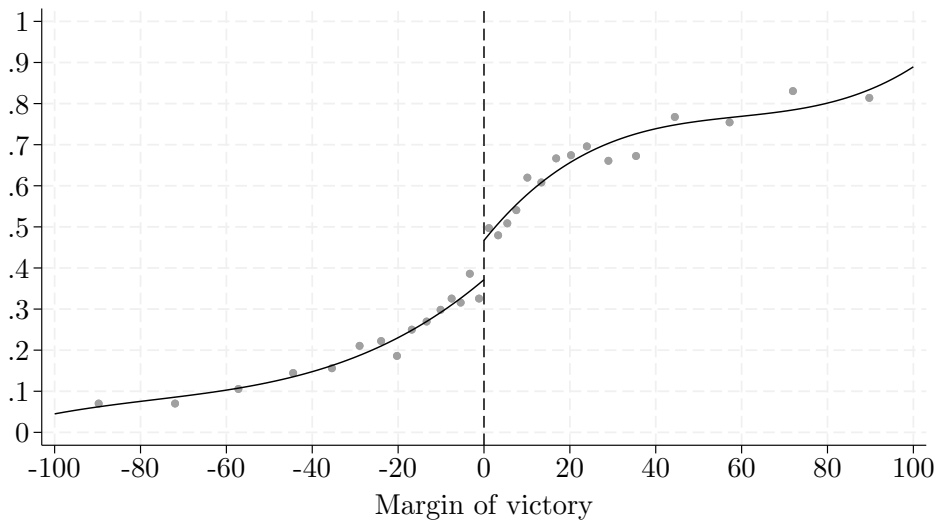
- We measure incumbency advantage as the causal effect of incumbency on the likelihood of being in power 180 days after the scheduled term end
- **Being in power:**
 - In presidential elections: Controlling the executive branch
 - In parliamentary elections: Holding a plurality of seats in the lower house of parliament

Estimation

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \beta T_{ic} + \gamma X_{ic} + \delta T_{ic} X_{ic} + \varepsilon_{ic}.$$

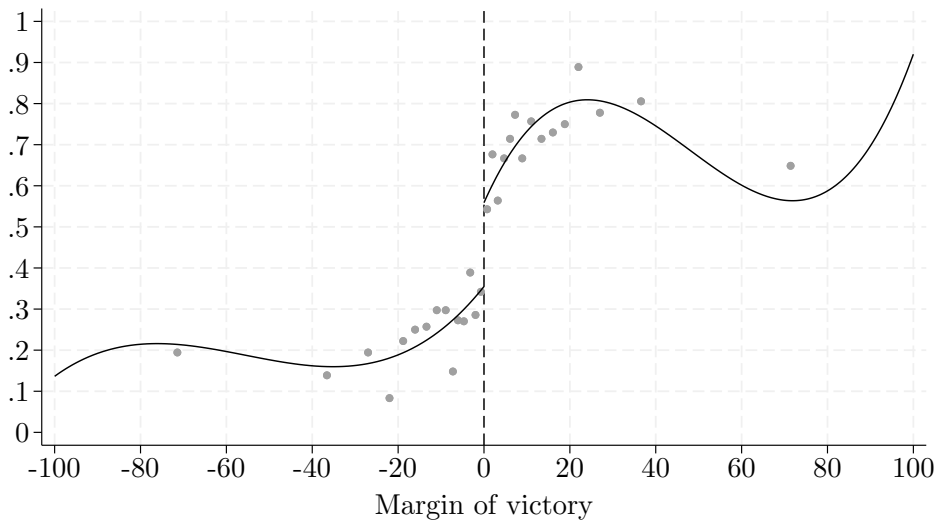
- Two observations for each election i (one for the winner, one for the runner-up)
- X_{ict} is c 's margin of victory in the election at time t
 - In vote shares, in presidential elections
 - In seat shares, in parliamentary elections
- $T_{ict} = 1$ if c won election at time t
- Y_{ic} : dummy equal to 1 if c is in power 180 days after the scheduled end of term

Full sample



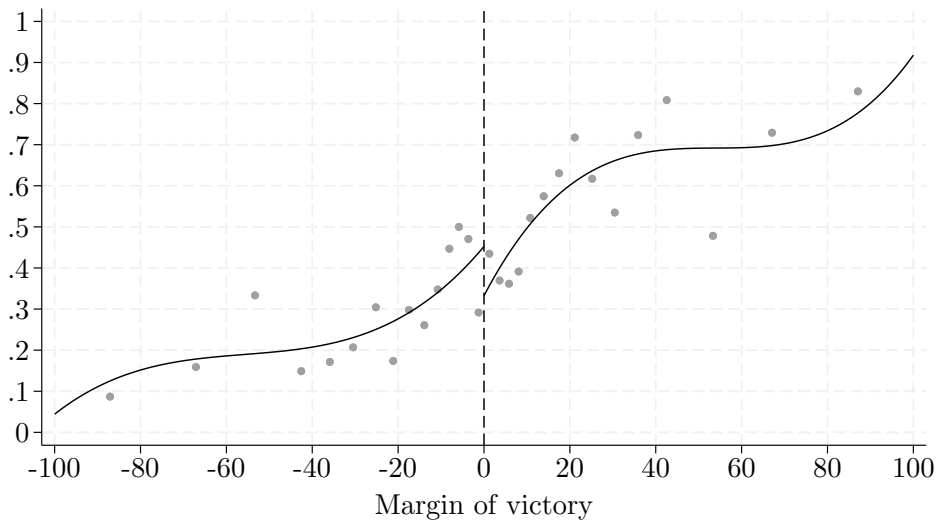
RD est.: 0.096 [-0.008, 0.178]. p-value: 0.072. N = 5138

North America and Western Europe



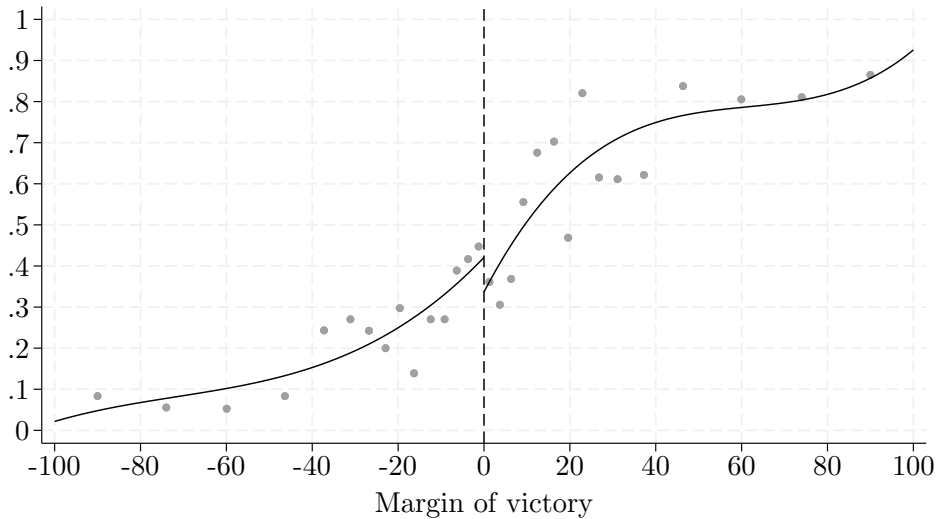
RD est.: 0.257 [0.090, 0.400]. p-value: 0.002. N = 1084

Latin America



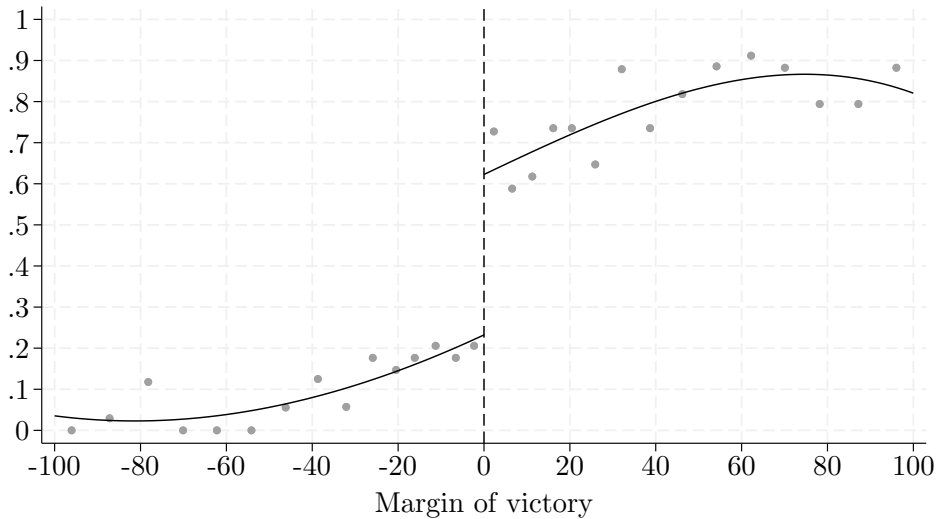
RD est.: -0.076 [-0.251, 0.109]. p-value: 0.439. N = 1390

Asia and Oceania



RD est.: -0.210 [-0.454, -0.050]. p-value: 0.015. N = 1100

Africa



RD est.: 0.429 [0.229, 0.642]. p-value: <0.001. N = 1016

Mechanisms: Decomposing the incumbency advantage

No election

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No subsequent election
has been held
 $(\gamma_{ic}^{\text{no election}})$

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Free & fair

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At least one subsequent
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last of which was free and fair
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Run RDD on each component: the total effect is the sum of three mutually exclusive channels.

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Postponement / cancellation

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Democratic advantage

Not free & fair

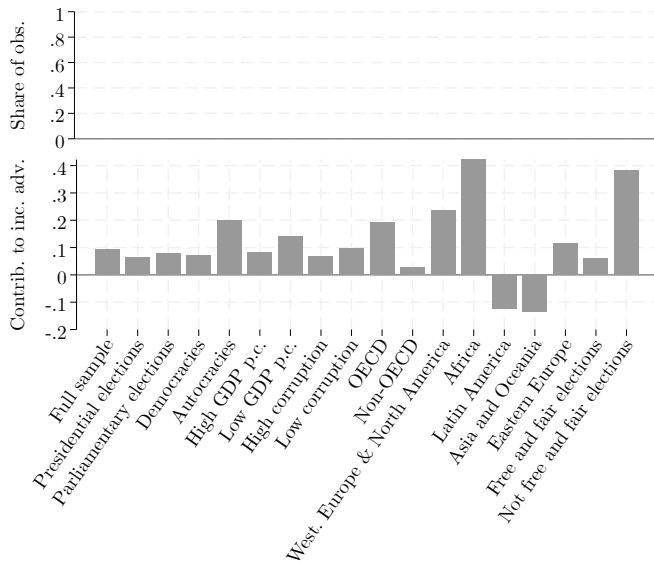
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Advantage in flawed contests

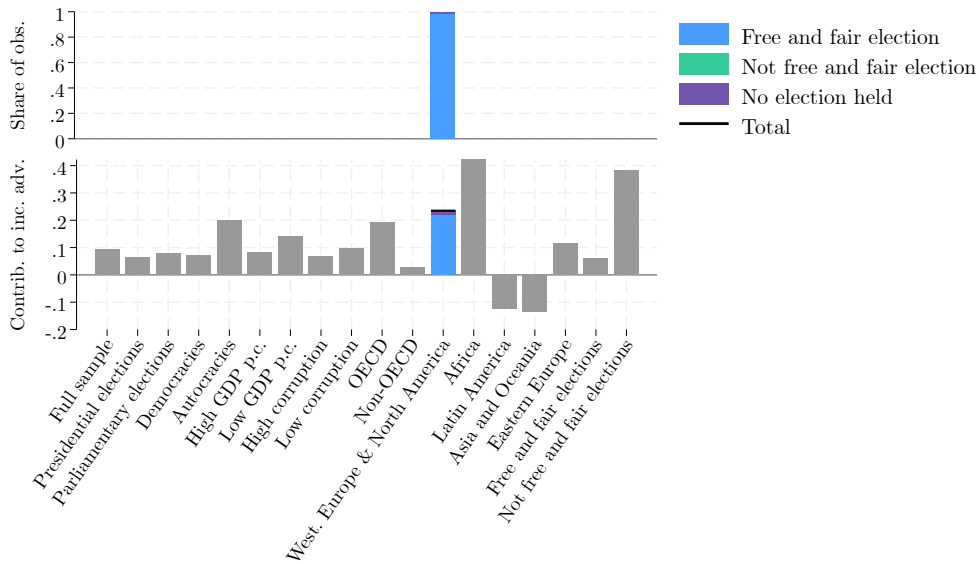
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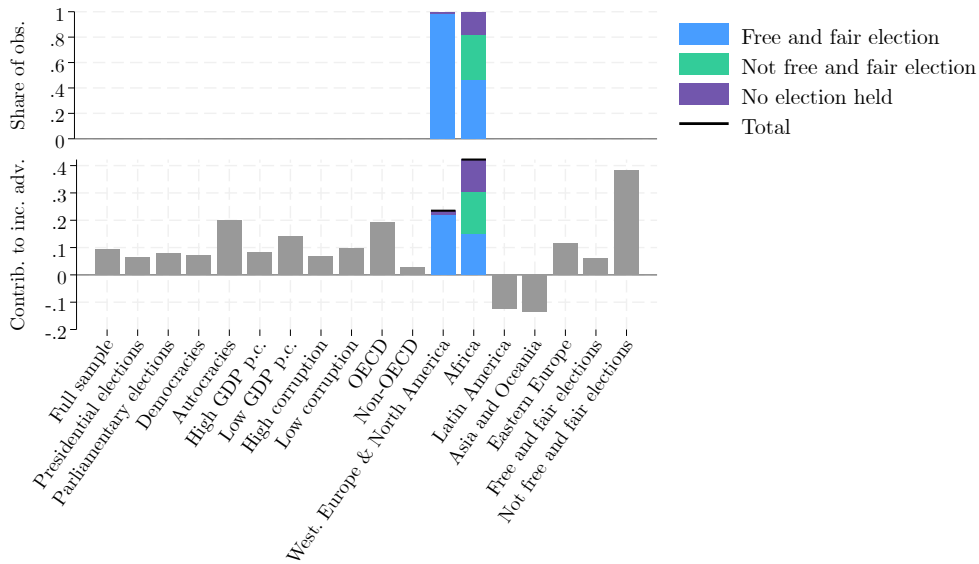
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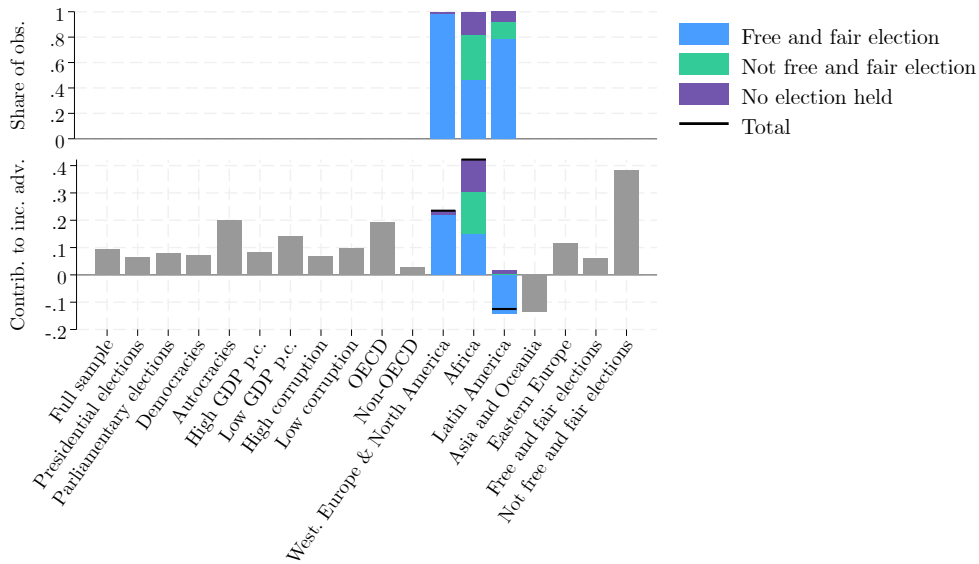
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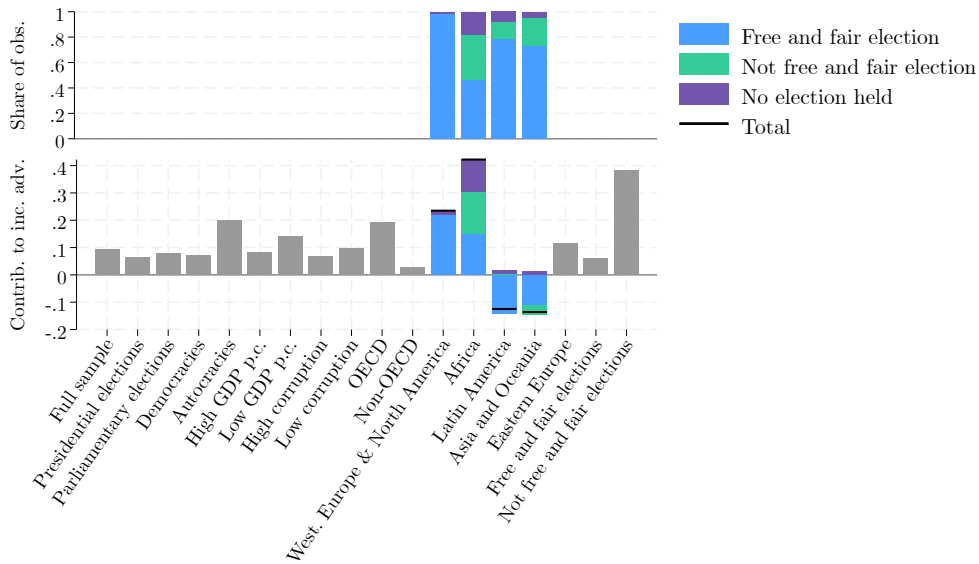
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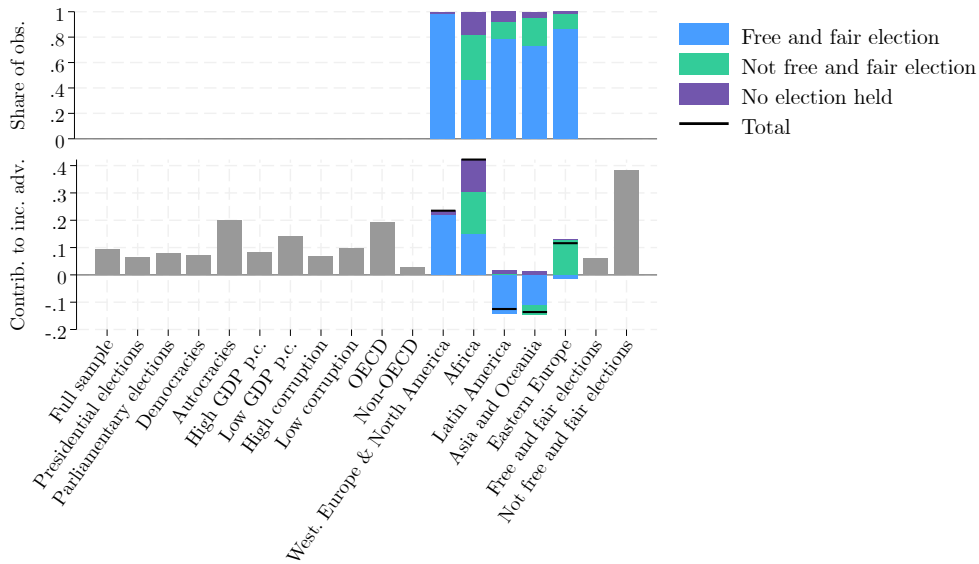
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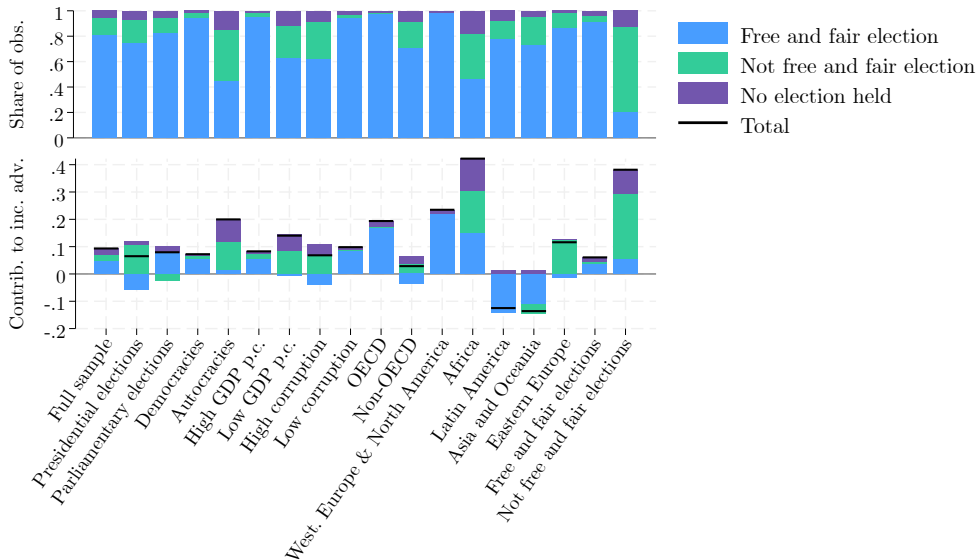
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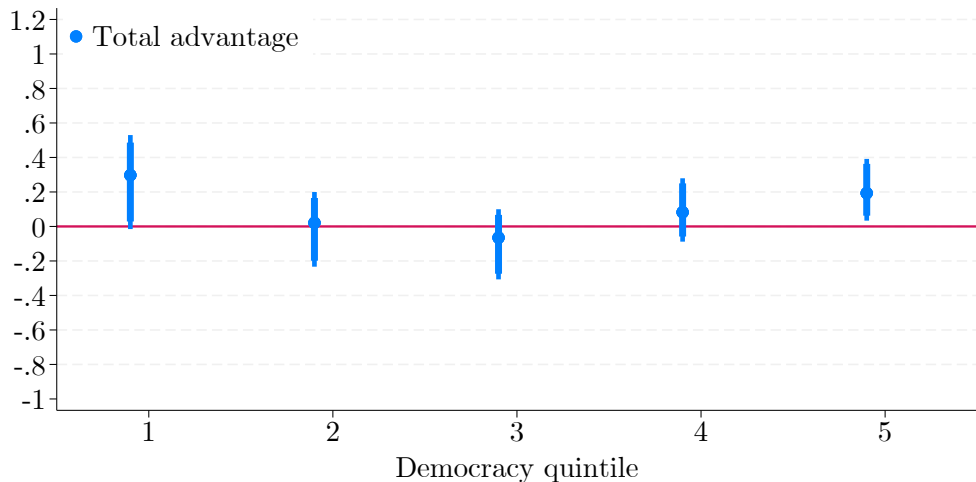
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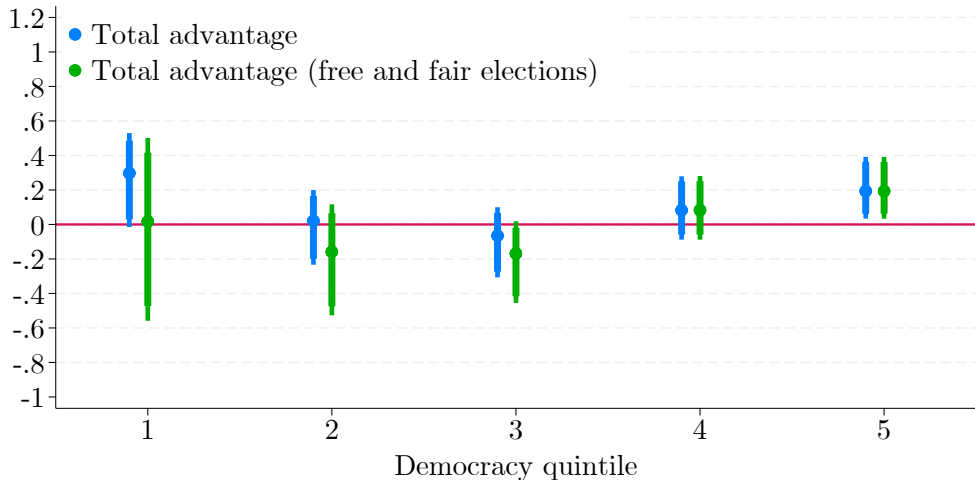


Incumbency advantage by level of democracy



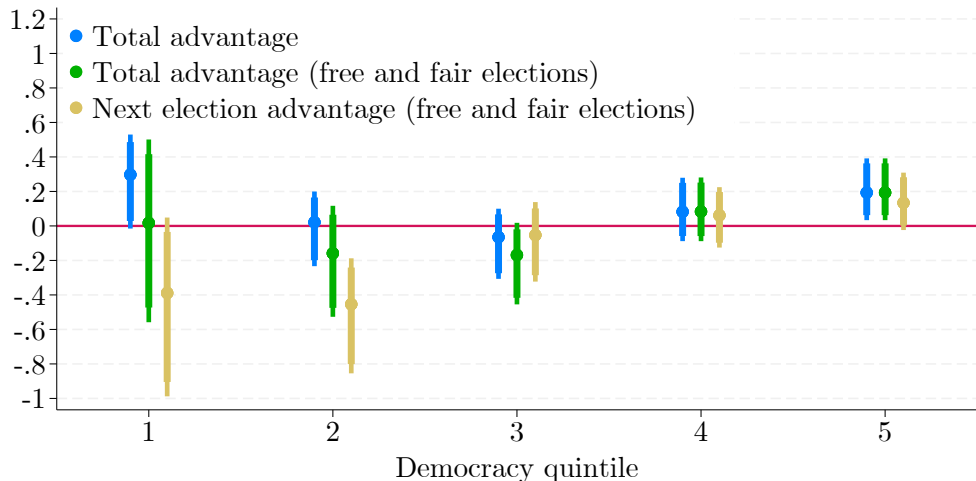
- **Total incumbency advantage:** non-linear relationship between the advantage & democracy

Incumbency advantage by level of democracy



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Incumbency advantage by level of democracy



- **Total incumbency advantage:** U-shaped relationship between incumbency effects and democracy
- **Next-election incumbency advantage:** monotonic relationship → consistent with meta-analysis

Conclusion

- At the subnational level, GDP per capita, corruption, and quality of democracy are important predictors of the incumbency (dis)advantage
- At the national level, non-linear relationship between the incumbency advantage and levels of economic development and democratic quality
 - Incumbency advantage in North America & Western Europe, Africa
 - Incumbency disadvantage in Latin America and in Asia and Oceania